Guardian Installation Troubleshooting



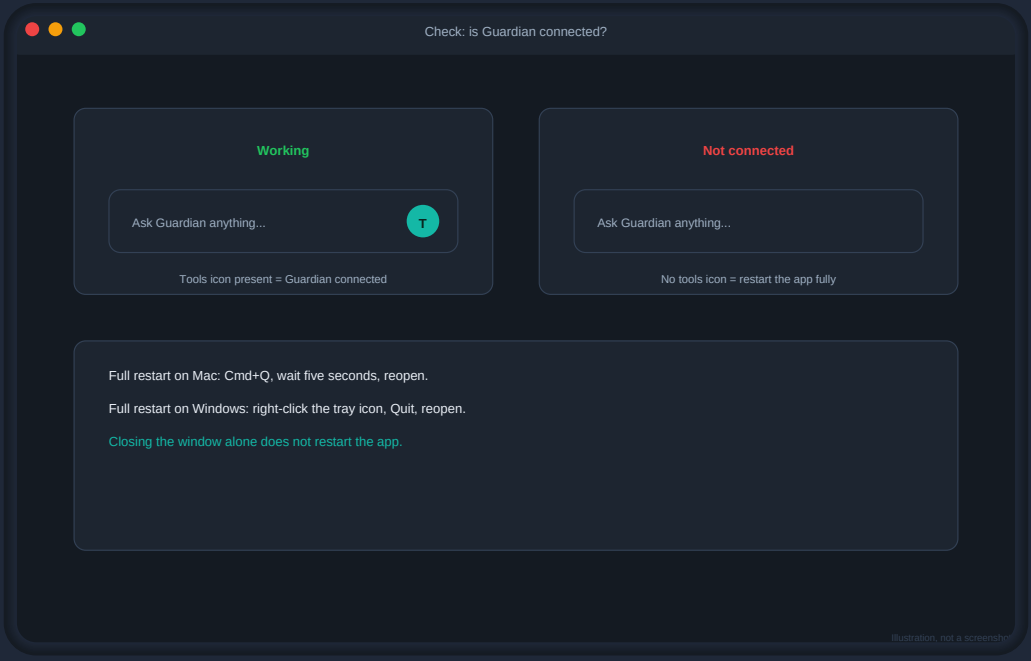
Every fix in this guide is a restart, a click, or a re-download. Nothing here needs a terminal. The step images are drawn illustrations of the flow, not captured screenshots.

Fast triage

What you are seeing	Try this first	Section
No Guardian anywhere after installing	Quit the app completely, then reopen	Does not appear
The license prompt keeps returning	Click Accept and Activate in the widget	License prompt
Still no tools icon after a restart	Reinstall the package	Tools icon missing

What you are seeing	Try this first	Section
Key rejected or tier looks wrong	Paste the whole key, dashes included	License key
Windows blocked the download	Choose More info, then Run anyway	Windows warning

Guardian does not appear after installing



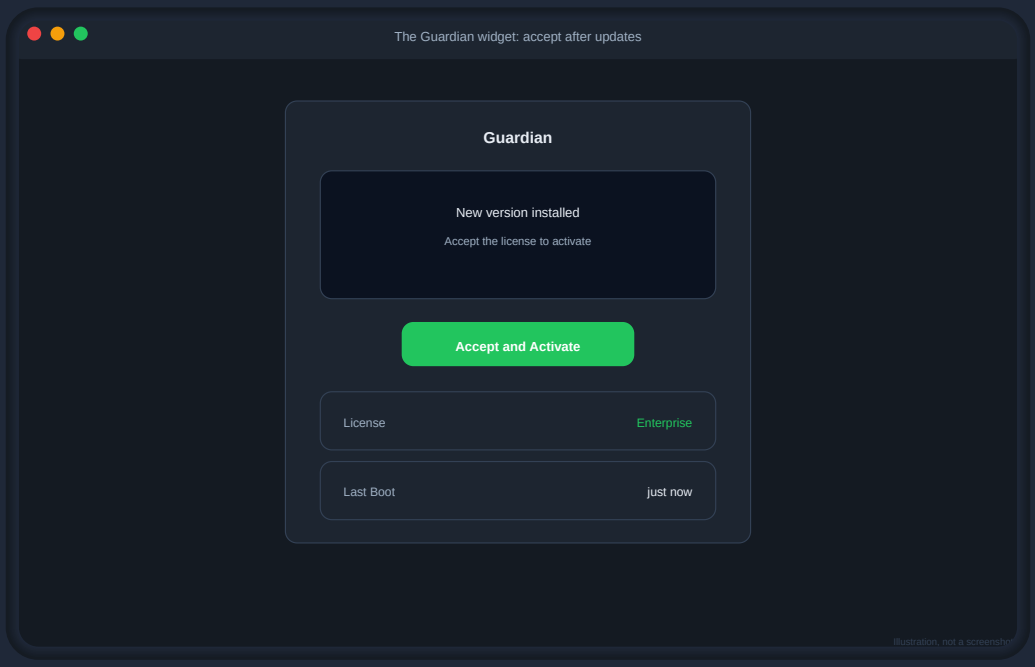
Look for the tools icon near the message box

The app loads extensions at startup, so a full restart fixes this most of the time.

- Mac: press Cmd+Q to quit completely, wait five seconds, reopen.
- Windows: right-click the app's tray icon, choose Quit, reopen.

> **The usual trap.** Closing the window leaves the app running in the background, so the extension never reloads. Quit it properly, then reopen.

"Accept the license" keeps appearing, or Guardian stays inactive



Accept and Activate in the Guardian widget

Click Accept and Activate in the Guardian widget, the small status window that opens with Guardian. After every update Guardian waits for one fresh acceptance before it runs. One click clears it.

The tools icon is still missing after a restart

1. Reinstall the plugin: Settings, then Extensions, remove Guardian, then drag the .plugin file in again.
2. Zip-package installs only: install Node.js 24 from nodejs.org, then run the installer again. The Windows installer never needs this step because its runtime is built in.

My license key is not taking

– Keys look like `GRD-ENT-XXXX-XXXX`. Paste the whole key, dashes included.
– Enter it in the widget: open the Plan menu, paste the key, click Apply.
– No key at all runs the free Scout tier. That is normal operation, not an error.

Windows warns about the download

SmartScreen sometimes flags fresh downloads. Choose More info, then Run anyway. If company policy blocks the installer entirely, use the .cmd fallback from the same releases page. When in doubt, compare your download against SHA256SUMS.txt on the releases page; matching checksums mean an intact file.

Before you report

Run this list first. It resolves most reports on its own.

Check	Why it matters
Full quit and reopen, not just closing the window	Extensions load at startup only.
The license accepted in the widget	Guardian stays inactive until it is accepted.
Checksum matches SHA256SUMS.txt	Rules out a truncated download.
You are on the current release	Older packages can miss the newest fixes.

Reporting a problem

Send these five things with any report, and the first reply can usually be the answer instead of a question:

What to send	Why it helps
Your Guardian version	Fixes differ between releases.
Your operating system	Mac and Windows fail in different places.
Which package you installed	Plugin, installer, and zip behave differently.
Which AI app you connected it to	Each surface loads Guardian its own way.
What you saw on screen	The exact wording points at the cause.

Keep secrets out of the report. Leave license keys and private files out of any screenshot you send. A cropped image of the error is enough.

What a healthy install looks like

Signal	What a healthy install shows
The tools icon	Present near the message box in a new conversation.
"Guardian status"	Comes back naming a tier and a mode.
The widget	Opens with Guardian and shows the license as accepted.
A document request	Comes back gated, with the mode line reading Enforce.

Still stuck

- Reinstalling from the releases page clears most states that a restart cannot.
- The install guide has the full path for every package type.
- Include your Guardian version (2.8.31) in any report; it is the first thing anyone will ask for.

End of the Guardian 2.8.31 troubleshooting guide

The releases page carries the current version and its checksums.